And then there is *blight*—the consequence of many of these scenarios.

Blight

Blight is a general term for most any disease in a plant that is caused by a pathogen.

Baltimore: If you want something to wipe out humanity, there might be no better way than a blight that attacks plants. We are dependent on plants to eat. Yes, we can eat animals or fish instead, but they ate plants.

Meyerowitz: It might be sufficient for the blight just to kill off the grasses and nothing else. Grasses are the basis of most of our agriculture: rice, corn, barley, sorghum, wheat. And most animals that we eat feed on grasses.

Meyerowitz: We already live in a world where 50 percent of the food grown is destroyed by pathogens, and it's much higher than that in Africa. Fungi, bacteria, viruses, . . . they all can be pathogens. The East Coast used to be covered with chestnut trees. They are no more. They were killed by a blight. The species of banana preferred by most people in the eighteenth century was wiped out by a blight. The replacement species, the Cavendish banana, today is being threatened by blight.

Kip: I thought that blights are *specialists* that attack only one narrow group of plants and don't jump to others.

Leadbetter: There are also *generalist* blights. There seems to be a tradeoff between being a generalist that attacks many species and a